

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

BIPAI_Botswana_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

Baylor International Pediatric AIDS Initiative (BIPAI)

Fellowship City

Gaborone

Fellowship Country

Botswana

Fellowship Start Date

07/20/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/20/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Project Assistant

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Coordinates volunteer program and oversees the recruitment and staffing of volunteers
- Coordinates the development of curricula and toolkits for volunteer tutoring services and teen club programs
- Assists with the programmatic elements of Camp Hope, a family weekend psychosocial intervention focused on improving adherence and mental health
- Compiles the Center of Excellence's Annual Report
- Pilots a study into barriers to accessing SRH services for adolescents and youth living with HIV

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Neutral

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

I shadowed the previous PiAf fellow for three days. The PiAf fellow left shortly after that, so I would go to my supervisor with questions that I had about my roles and responsibilities.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?
Describe a representative day at work.

I would usually get to work at 7:30am and leave around 4:30pm. My days earlier in the week consist of tracking attendance for the past week's tutoring, attending meetings, interviewing volunteers, getting the contact information for newly referred tutees, finalizing teen club materials and piloting the SRH study instruments. On Thursdays and Fridays, I would be preparing for weekend programs. For tutoring, this would mean texting and calling tutees and tutors with reminders.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Neutral

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

For Camp Hope, I was mainly responsible for planning and scheduling programs and supervising the activity leaders that would be delivering the programs. The whole camp ran quite smoothly and I received feedback from supervisors that this would be the schedule that they would adopt for future camps.

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I work at the Phatsimong Adolescent Center, which has about 8-10 staff. I share an office with three other colleagues. Everyone has a good working relationship and our programs overlap a lot so we regularly work together. I also sometimes work from the clinic, which is much bigger and is right across the street from the adolescent center.

To whom do you report?

I primarily report to the Senior Program Officer regarding all aspects of my work. I also report to the Training Coordinator for research-related roles and the annual report writing.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?
Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.
Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

- Learn more about project management
- Learn more about working in an NGO
- Continue conducting research

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?

Please provide more information on your response above.

I would ultimately want to build a career in global health that is split between programming and research. At BIPAI, I get to do both and I have been learning so much about youth-focused psychosocial programming during my time here.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Irregularly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).**I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.**

Disagree

Please briefly explain your response.

I am the only person coordinating the tutoring program, which has no funding and no solid structure. I am very new to project management and really could use some support and guidance on it.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I bought my tickets online from the Ethiopian Airlines website. I flew in on a direct flight from Addis Ababa, Ethiopia to Gaborone, Botswana. The round-trip tickets cost around \$800.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I had a business visa and have converted it to a work exemption since

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I applied for a business visa since I was being sponsored by the organization and not an individual. After I arrived in Botswana, I applied for an exemption and BIPAI helped me throughout the process.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

no

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

The visa application fees were \$50. The permit cost approximately \$150.

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I covered the visa costs, my organization paid for the permit

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Consult with the embassy regarding the type of visa that would work best for you.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

The yellow fever vaccine. All my vaccinations are from previous travel, so I do not remember how much they cost.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

I arrived on a holiday, but BIPAI arranged a cab driver to come pick me up from the airport. The previous PiAf fellow helped me get sim cards and buy groceries, etc. Tip for future fellows - check if there are any national holidays in Botswana around your planned date of arrival and avoid arriving during those days.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Yes, housing is provided by Baylor Botswana. They cover utilities as well.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

The house is a bit far from the workplace but it's a pretty safe, quiet, and clean neighborhood. It is very close to a shopping center, so it is relatively easy to get groceries and other stuff.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I take combis to work, which are 7 pulas per ride. I sometimes take cabs, which cost around 40 pulas. The commute usually takes 10 minutes without traffic and 20-30 minutes during rush hour.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

I live in an urban area

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

We are in the summer. It is really hot already (reaches around 39 degrees celsius) and is getting hotter each week. It rains sometimes and brings the temperature down.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

People at work usually dress in formal work attire. Outside of work, there are no set rules on what you are expected to wear. Some people, especially older ones, will look at you weird if you wear revealing attire. Just be mindful of the places you will be going to and if what you are wearing is appropriate for the occasion/location.

How have you been spending your free time?

I spend a lot of my time with colleagues from work and other friends I made outside of work. We have a work group that hangs out once every two weeks. I also go to the gym regularly and go to driving school as well. I think Gabs is small so once you know someone, then you get to meet other cool people as well.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

All my family and friends are in Ethiopia, which is only an hour ahead. This makes it really easy to catch up and keep regular communication. I usually use whatsapp, telegram and Instagram to stay in touch

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Both my work and home are in pretty safe neighborhoods. I avoid walking around after dark since there has been an increase in crime.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

- avoid walking after dark
- keep my personal belongings safely in your bag

- avoid wearing expensive jewelry
- avoid using your phone at traffic stops

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have not experienced any crime so far.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Gaborone is generally safe but it is still good to avoid going to small bars. BIPAI provides housing and a security guard for the house so do not worry about safe housing.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I am still working on my goals. One thing that I would like to continue working on is focusing on my mental health. Between work and socializing, I rarely make time for myself to just relax and reflect.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I wish we lived closer to work. It is very frustrating traveling to and from work at peak traffic, which seems very difficult to avoid unless I leave my place an hour before work starts and leave work 30 minutes after it ends.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

no

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I have surprisingly not dealt with any culture shock

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I really thought Gaborone would be so much bigger than it is. It is a relatively small city and there isn't much to do around here. I am definitely still getting used to the calmness of things here cause I am used to a more energetic environment back home.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Work gets done at a slower pace. It takes a long time for tasks to be completed and often requires me to follow-up intensely.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

I miss the food
I miss going out during weekends to parks, events etc
I miss cooler weather

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

You can drink the tap water
It is a more multicultural space
The animals and sunsets

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly in USD to a local account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

no

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$30.00	\$0.00	\$50.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$100.00	\$50.00	\$50.00	\$200.00	\$0.00	\$100.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$100.00	630.00
Specify "Other"					
Driving school					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I received good information about preparing for my fellowship post.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

One thing that would be helpful would be to have country-specific information about using our health insurance.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Information on staying connected past the fellowship and post-fellowship guidance would be appreciated.